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Municipal structures

3.13 Municipal structures

Street, road, path, way, track

3.13.1 Street, road, path, way, track

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Greek πλατεῖα, πλατύς (plateia, platus) MAT 6:5, MAT 12:19, LUK 10:10, LUK 13:26, LUK 14:21, ACT 5:15, REV 11:8, REV 21:21, REV 22:2, TOB 2:4, TOB 13:17, JDT 1:14, JDT 7:14, JDT 7:22, SIR 23:21, 1MA 1:55, 1MA 2:9, 1MA 14:9, 3MA 1:18

Greek ῥύμη (rhumē) MAT 6:2, LUK 14:21, ACT 9:11, ACT 12:10, SIR 9:7

Greek τρίβος (tribos) SIR 2:12

Greek τροχιά (trochia) HEB 12:13

Latin platea 2ES 1:13

Latin semita 2ES 7:8

Latin via 2ES 16:33

Description and usage:

Roman road of Tell Aquibrin (© Bernard Gagnon, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons)This entry includes a variety of roads, either shorter ones within a town or village or longer ones between cities and even countries. Most roads were not paved but were simply paths worn by the passage of many feet and vehicles. Some roads between cites (especially in the Roman period) and more streets within cities and towns were paved, usually with stones.

Translation:

Some languages contain a wide variety of words for roads within settled areas like towns or cities and also between such urban units. Hebrew and Greek are no exception, with at least a dozen such words. While some of the words are general terms, others indicate roads differing in width, length, or purpose. Translators will, of course, want to choose words in their language that take the context into consideration.

Most of the roads mentioned in the Bible would have been local ways that were little more than wide walking paths. These were usually unpaved, followed the topography, and for the most part would not have been used by vehicles. Some of the roads mentioned in the New Testament were Roman roads and were specially prepared and paved with stone. This kind of road is mentioned, for example, in MRK 10:46. Strictly speaking, the roads within towns were not “man-made” in the sense that they were not specially constructed according to some plan. They were simply the product of the space between buildings.

Some languages make a distinction between a road inside a town or city and one that passes through the countryside. Where the context is not clear and the language does not have a generic word for “road,” it will usually be best to select a word for a road that connects towns.

As with many languages, words for thoroughfares in Hebrew and Greek often serve figuratively to indicate the “way” a person lives or does something; for example, PSA 1:1 praises the person who does not “follow the example of sinners” (GNT). The Hebrew text says literally “does not stand in the way of sinners.” Here a literal translation into English is a mistranslation, because the English idiom “to stand in someone’s way” means to prevent them from acting. NIV renders this verse literally by saying “Blessed is the man who does not ... stand in the way of sinners ... ,” which praises the person who allows sinners to do wrong. This, of course, is not the message of the text.

It is not clear just what Solomon built with algum wood in 2CH 9:11. The hilly topography of Jerusalem and the fact that Solomon used wood indicate that he could have made a kind of path “paved” with wood or even a kind of “boardwalk.” For the Hebrew word msilahNJPSV has “ramps,” and NKJV says “walkways.” Many translations say “steps” (RSV, NASB) here but inconsistently translate this word everywhere else as “highway,” “road,” or “path.”

The Hebrew words ma’gal and ma’galah are related to the word for “wagon” or “ox-cart” (see 8.2 Cart, wagon<REALIA:8.2>) and indicate the track in which the wheels of a wagon would go.

MAT 6:2: The word “streets” in this verse follows the Greek text and is the rendering of most translations (for example, RSV, GNT); Anchor Bible has “market places.” In some languages it may sound odd to have the people standing out in the middle of busy streets praying; any place where large crowds of people normally gather for daily activities, such as “marketplaces” or “street corners” (CEV), would seem a more satisfactory rendering. So instead of “in the streets,” translators may say “out in the middle of towns” or “in the busy parts of towns.” Also in JDT 1:14 the rendering “marketplaces” (so NJB, NAB) is better than “streets.”

Square, marketplace

3.13.2 Square, marketplace

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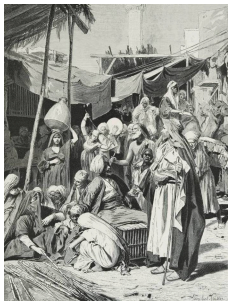
Greek ἀγορανομία (agoranomia) 2MA 3:4

Greek εὐρύχωρος (euruchōros) 1ES 5:46, 1ES 9:6, 1ES 9:38, 1ES 9:41

Description:



Marketplace inside Tantah (© Leopold Carl Müller - Wikimedia Commons)The square was an open place in a town or city, often formed by the intersection of two or more streets (see 3.13.1 Street, road, path, way, track<REALIA:3.13.1>). Like the streets, the square was usually unpaved, only sometimes paved with stones. The square was open to the sky and often served as a gathering place for the inhabitants of the city. One of the squares of a town usually served as a marketplace, a central location for bartering, buying, and selling.

Translation:

Many cultures, where people live in permanent settlements, will know an open place in the middle of a settlement used for public gatherings.

In biblical times one such open area, which was often the most important one in the city, stood inside the city wall, near the gates. In this place, town administration meetings (DEU 21:19), legal transactions (RUT 4:1, RUT 4:11), and markets (2KI 7:1, 2KI 7:18) were held (see 3.13.3.5 City gate<REALIA:3.13.3.5>). It will sometimes be possible in translation to indicate the place by the activity that is taking place there rather than by a word that corresponds to “square.” A good example of this is the way GNT renders JOB 29:7. The Hebrew reads literally “When I went out to the gate of the city, when I prepared my seat in the square” (RSV); GNT says “Whenever the city elders met and I took my place among them.” Compare also GNT at PRO 7:12: “or stood waiting at a corner, sometimes in the streets, sometimes in the marketplace.”

While most translations and commentaries understand the Hebrew word rchov to mean “city square,” some understand it in the more general sense of “street” in some passages (and this indeed has become its only meaning in modern Hebrew); for example, KJV renders it “street[s]” in all but three instances, and NIV, while usually rendering rchov as “square[s],” has “streets” in about one-third of its appearances. By way of example, most translations render rchovoth in DAN 9:25 as “streets”; some common-language translations (GECL, FRCL, ITCL) avoid a direct translation of rchovoth by speaking of “Jerusalem” being reconstructed.

City fortifications

3.13.3 City fortifications

Ancient cities were often built with special fortifications to protect the inhabitants from attacks from the outside. Sometimes the fortifications were natural, for example, on the top of a steep hill or next to a river. Man-made fortifications included at least a high, thick wall, usually made of bricks or stones. A city wall had one or more entrances, which were closed with gates. The gates were usually made of wood. The entranceway itself was often quite complex, involving one or more turns and several guardrooms. The gate, as well as the rest of the wall, could be supplemented with towers that stood up higher than the wall. These towers served both as vantage points from which to see someone approaching from a distance and also as high points from which missiles could be dropped or thrown on an attacking enemy.

City wall, rampart, battlement

3.13.3.1 City wall, rampart, battlement

References:

Hebrew גְּבוּל (gvul) ISA 54:12

Hebrew גָּדֵר (gader) MIC 7:11

Hebrew חֵיל, חַיִל (chel, chayil, cheylah) 2SA 20:15, 1KI 21:23, PSA 48:14, PSA 122:7, ISA 26:1, LAM 2:8, NAM 3:8

Hebrew חוֹמָה (chomah) EXO 14:22, EXO 14:29, LEV 25:29, LEV 25:30, LEV 25:31, DEU 3:5, DEU 28:52, JOS 6:5, JOS 6:20, 1SA 31:10, 1SA 31:12, 2SA 11:20, 2SA 11:21, 2SA 11:21, 2SA 11:24, 2SA 18:24, 2SA 20:15, 2SA 20:21, 2KI 3:27, 2KI 6:26, 2KI 6:30, 2KI 14:13, 2KI 18:26, 2KI 18:27, 2KI 25:4, 2CH 8:5, 2CH 14:6, 2CH 25:23, 2CH 26:6, 2CH 26:6, 2CH 26:6, 2CH 27:3, 2CH 32:5, 2CH 32:18, 2CH 33:14, 2CH 36:19, PSA 51:20, PSA 55:11, PRO 25:28, SNG 5:7, SNG 8:9, SNG 8:10, ISA 2:15, ISA 22:10, ISA 22:11, ISA 26:1, ISA 30:13, ISA 36:11, ISA 36:12, ISA 49:16, ISA 56:5, ISA 60:10, ISA 60:18, ISA 62:6, JER 1:15, JER 1:18, JER 15:20, JER 21:4, JER 52:7, JER 52:14, LAM 2:8, LAM 2:8, LAM 2:18, EZK 26:4, EZK 26:9, EZK 26:10, EZK 26:12, EZK 27:11, EZK 27:11, EZK 38:11, EZK 38:20, JOL 2:7, JOL 2:9, AMO 1:7, AMO 1:10, AMO 1:14, AMO 7:7, NAM 2:6, NAM 3:8, ZEC 2:9

Hebrew מְצוּרָה (mtsurah) NAM 2:2

Hebrew קִיר (qir) NUM 22:25, NUM 22:25, NUM 35:4, JOS 2:15, ISA 25:4

Hebrew שׁוּר (shur) 2SA 22:30, EZR 4:12, EZR 4:12, EZR 4:13, EZR 4:16, PSA 18:30

Greek ἔπαλξις (epalxis) JDT 14:1, SIR 9:13

Greek προμαχών (promachōn) TOB 13:17

Greek τεῖχος (teichos) ACT 9:25, 2CO 11:33, HEB 11:30, REV 21:12, REV 21:14, REV 21:15, REV 21:17, REV 21:18, REV 21:19, TOB 1:17, TOB 13:17, JDT 1:2, JDT 1:2, JDT 7:32

Greek χάραξ (charax) 4MA 3:12

Latin murus 2ES 2:22, 2ES 11:42, 2ES 15:42

Description:

Model of the Herodian city wall of Jerusalem (Israel Museum) (© Ray Pritz by United Bible Societies)A strong, permanent wall was built around a city or fortress for its protection. Some cities were even surrounded by two walls. The outer wall had to be breached before the inner one could be attacked. This outer wall is sometimes called the rampart. A single wall or the inner one of two walls was most often built of stone, sometimes of mud brick. The outer wall could also be made of one of these materials or simply of piled earth.

The battlement or parapet was the uppermost part of a defensive wall. It was built with openings through which soldiers could look and use their weapons.

Translation:

City walls are not part of municipal structures in most parts of the world today, and it is often necessary to employ a descriptive phrase to render "city walls," for example, "walls that protect the city from its enemies" or "walls that keep the enemy outside the city." In many areas a fence of bushes, branches, earth, or stones is placed around a house or garden to protect it, and the term used for such a protection may be appropriate. However, such a fence may not be wide enough for people to walk on. Where the text speaks of people walking or doing other things on the city wall, translators should avoid creating a picture that will look impossible or ridiculous to the readers. In such cases, it may be necessary to expand with something like "thick fence made of stones around a city" or "fortified fence around a city."

The Hebrew words chel and chomah appear several times parallel to each other. There may be some distinction between them, where chel speaks of extra fortification or strengthening of a chomah. However, where only one term for a city wall exists, it will usually be possible to treat them as one term. Where chel and its related terms stand alone, translators may add a modifier, saying "strong wall" or "fortified wall."

In a few places (1SA 25:16; PRO 18:11; SNG 8:9; SNG 8:10; ISA 26:1; JER 15:20; ZEC 2:9) the word chomah is used figuratively, signifying strength or protection. In 1SA 25:16GNT has dropped the wall figure and begins simply with "They protected us."

JOS 2:15 refers to Rahab's "house built into the city wall" (GNT). Archaeological excavations reveal that at one time Jericho had two city walls, an inner one and an outer one, separated by a space of about 3.5 to 4.5 meters (11.5–14.5 feet). Houses were built on heavy timbers laid from one wall to the other. The window through which Rahab let the men down looked out from the outer wall. The phrase "a house built into the city wall" could possibly be unclear; it may be more satisfactory to translate "a section of the city wall formed the outside wall of Rahab's house." Moreover, it may even be necessary to include a footnote, indicating more precisely the relation between the house and the city wall.

JDT 14:1: Where a technical term for "parapet" does not exist or is obscure, it is possible to render the literal phrase "the parapet of your wall" in this verse as "the town wall" (GNT) or "the top of the town wall" (CEV).

Fortress, stronghold, castle, citadel, fort

3.13.3.2 Fortress, stronghold, castle, citadel, fort

References:

Hebrew בִּירָה (birah) 2CH 17:12, 2CH 27:4, NEH 2:8, NEH 7:2

Hebrew מִבְצָר (mivtsar) 2SA 24:7, 2KI 8:12, PSA 89:41, ISA 17:3, ISA 34:13, JER 48:18, LAM 2:2, LAM 2:5, DAN 11:39, HOS 10:14, AMO 5:9, MIC 5:10, NAM 3:12, NAM 3:14, HAB 1:10

Hebrew מִגְדַּל־שְׁכֶם (migdal shkem) JDG 9:46, JDG 9:47, JDG 9:49

Hebrew מִסְגֶּרֶת (misgereth) 2SA 22:46, PSA 18:46, MIC 7:17

Hebrew מָעוֹז (ma'oz) ISA 23:11, DAN 11:7, DAN 11:10, DAN 11:10, DAN 11:19, DAN 11:31, DAN 11:38, DAN 11:39

Hebrew מְצָד, מְצוּדָה (mtsad, mtsudah) 2SA 5:7, 2SA 5:9, 1CH 11:5, 1CH 11:7, JER 48:41, JER 51:30

Hebrew מָצוֹר (matsor) ZEC 9:3

Hebrew מְצוּרָה (mtsurah) 2CH 11:11, 2CH 11:23, 2CH 12:4, 2CH 14:5, 2CH 21:3

Hebrew מִשְׂגָּב (misgav) 2SA 22:3, PSA 9:10, PSA 9:10, PSA 18:3, PSA 46:8, PSA 46:12, PSA 48:4, PSA 59:10, PSA 59:17, PSA 59:18, PSA 62:3, PSA 62:7, PSA 94:22, PSA 144:2, ISA 25:12, ISA 33:16, JER 48:1

Hebrew צָרִיחַ (tsariach) JDG 9:46, JDG 9:49, JDG 9:49

Greek ἀκρόπολις (akropolis) 2MA 4:12, 2MA 4:28, 2MA 5:5

Greek ἄκρα (akra) 1MA 1:33, 1MA 3:45, 1MA 4:2, 1MA 4:41, 1MA 6:18, 1MA 6:26, 1MA 6:32, 1MA 9:52, 1MA 9:53, 1MA 10:7, 1MA 10:7, 1MA 10:9, 1MA 10:32, 1MA 11:21, 1MA 11:21, 1MA 11:41, 1MA 12:36, 1MA 13:21, 1MA 13:50, 1MA 13:50, 1MA 13:52, 1MA 14:7, 1MA 14:36, 1MA 15:28, 2MA 15:31, 2MA 15:35, 4MA 4:20

Greek βάρις (baris) 1ES 6:22

Greek ὀχύρωμα, ὀχυρωμάτιον (ochurōma, ochurōmation) 2CO 10:4, 1MA 1:2, 1MA 4:61, 1MA 5:9, 1MA 5:11, 1MA 5:27, 1MA 5:29, 1MA 5:30, 1MA 5:65, 1MA 6:61, 1MA 6:62, 1MA 8:10, 1MA 9:50, 1MA 10:12, 1MA 10:37, 1MA 11:18, 1MA 11:18, 1MA 11:41, 1MA 12:33, 1MA 12:34, 1MA 12:35, 1MA 12:45, 1MA 13:33, 1MA 13:33, 1MA 13:38, 1MA 14:42, 1MA 15:7, 1MA 16:8, 1MA 16:15, 2MA 8:30, 2MA 10:15, 2MA 10:16, 2MA 10:23, 2MA 10:32, 2MA 11:6, 2MA 12:19, 3MA 6:25

Greek φρούριον (frourion) 2MA 10:32, 2MA 10:33, 2MA 13:19

Description:

Model of the Antonia fortress in Jerusalem (© Ray Pritz by United Bible Societies)The fortress was a large fortification, often part of the defense of a town. In the Middle East such fortifications were built of stone. A fortress could consist of one extra strong building or of a complex of buildings surrounded by its own strong wall.

Translation:

In some languages the word “fortress” may be rendered in terms of its function, for example, “place for protection” or “place to defend oneself.” Often, however, a fortress is described in terms of its construction, for example, “strong-walled place.”

The Hebrew word birah in NEH 2:8; NEH 7:2 refers to a fortified enclosure that stood on the northwest corner of the Temple complex in Jerusalem to guard the Temple on the northern side, from which attacks were

most likely to come. It was later expanded and strengthened by Herod the Great and named the Antonia (see 3.20.1 Pavement, The Pavement<REALIA:3.20.1>). In NEH 2:8CEV renders the literal phrase “the fortress of the Temple” as “the fortress near the temple”; GNT has “the fort that guards the Temple”; REB says “the citadel, which adjoins the temple.”

The Hebrew phrase migdal shkem in JDG 9:47; JDG 9:47; JDG 9:49 is understood in various ways. Most English translations consulted have “tower of Shechem” or “fortress of Shechem”; some capitalize “Tower” (RSV), suggesting that it could be a place name. Many non-English translations (for example, SPCL, FRCL, DUCL, TOB) take it to be a place name and simply transliterate it (DUCL “Migdal-Sichem”).

In the New Testament the Greek term ochurōma occurs only in 2CO 10:4, where it is used figuratively of the strength of false arguments. In a number of languages it may be more satisfactory to render the word in a simile in order to mark this figurative usage; for example, the verse may be rendered “The weapons we use in our fight are not the world’s weapons but God’s powerful weapons with which to destroy false arguments in the same way that people would destroy fortresses.”

Watchtower, tower

3.13.3.3 Watchtower, tower

References:

Hebrew אַלְמָן (’alman) ISA 13:22

Hebrew בַּחַן (bachan) ISA 32:14

Hebrew מִגְדָּל, מִגְדֹּל (migdal, migdol) JDG 8:9, JDG 8:17, JDG 9:51, JDG 9:51, JDG 9:52, JDG 9:52, 2KI 9:17, 2KI 17:9, 2KI 18:8, 1CH 27:25, 2CH 14:6, 2CH 26:9, 2CH 26:15, 2CH 27:4, 2CH 32:5, NEH 3:1, NEH 3:1, NEH 3:11, NEH 3:25, NEH 3:26, NEH 3:27, NEH 12:38, NEH 12:39, NEH 12:39, PSA 48:13, PSA 61:4, PRO 18:10, SNG 4:4, SNG 5:13, SNG 7:5, SNG 7:5, SNG 8:10, ISA 2:15, ISA 30:25, ISA 33:18, JER 31:38, EZK 26:4, EZK 26:9, EZK 27:11, ZEC 14:10

Hebrew מָצוֹר (matsor) HAB 2:1

Hebrew מִצְפֶּה (mitspeh) ISA 21:8, 2CH 20:24

Hebrew פִּנָּה (pinah) 2CH 26:15, ZEP 1:16, ZEP 3:6

Hebrew שֶׁמֶשׁ (shemesh) ISA 54:12

Greek πύργος (purgos) MAT 21:33, MRK 12:1, LUK 13:4, LUK 14:28, TOB 13:14, TOB 13:17, JDT 1:3, JDT 1:14, JDT 7:5, JDT 7:32, 1MA 1:33, 1MA 4:60, 1MA 5:5, 1MA 5:5, 1MA 5:65, 1MA 13:33, 1MA 13:43, 1MA 16:10, 2MA 10:18, 2MA 10:20, 2MA 10:22, 2MA 10:36, 2MA 13:5, 2MA 14:41, 3MA 2:27, 4MA 13:6, 1ES 1:52, 1ES 4:4

Greek σκοπή (skopē) SIR 37:14

Description:

Model of a watchtower in a city wall (© Ray Pritz by United Bible Societies)The watchtower was a tall structure with a lookout at the top.

Usage:

Watchtowers were placed at intervals along city walls to watch for an approaching enemy. They also allowed the defenders of the city to shoot at an attacker from his flank. Sometimes towers were built on private property to protect it. See also 2.19.3 Firing platform, siege tower<REALIA:2.19.3>.

Translation:

In a number of languages the expression for “tower” is simply “high building” (though of course not a skyscraper). In other instances it may be more appropriately rendered “high platform” or “high lookout place.”

The Hebrew word ’alman in ISA 13:22 means literally “his widows.” It is very similar to a word meaning “palace” (see ’armon under 3.4 Palace<REALIA:3.4>). It is not clear if there is a textual corruption here or if the author has deliberately interchanged the letters in order to suggest “desolation” (see de Waard, A Handbook on Isaiah, page 61).

2CH 20:24: While some translations (for example, NRSV, GNT, CEV) translate the Hebrew word mitspeh as “tower” or “watchtower,” it is just as likely that the mitspeh was simply a high natural point from which a person had a good view. So where RSV has “the watchtower of the wilderness,” NIV says “the place that overlooks the desert,” NCV renders “a place where they could see the desert,” and ITCL has “a hill from which it was possible to see the desert.”

The Hebrew word pinah is literally “corner.” In the references given the word may not necessarily mean a distinct structure but rather just a corner of the city wall. In ZEP 1:16 some translations have “corner towers” (NIV, NJPSV), while others are more general with “lofty battlements” (RSV; similarly NLT).

Some older translations (for example, KJV) rendered the Hebrew word tsafith as “watchtower” in ISA 21:5. It is now commonly accepted that it means “carpet” (see 5.17 Carpet, rug<REALIA:5.17>).

In the New Testament the Greek word purgos may designate any type of tower, whether employed for military purposes or used by watchmen protecting a harvest (see 1.1.11 Watchtower<REALIA:1.1.11>). In LUK 13:4 the tower was probably part of the ancient walls of Jerusalem.

Moat

3.13.3.4 Moat

Reference:

Hebrew חָרוּץ (charuts) DAN 9:25

Description and usage:

Ruins of a fortress surrounded by a moat (Kokhav Hayarden, Crusader fortress overlooking the Beit Shean valley) (© Ya'acov Sa'ar, Israel Government Press Office)The moat was a wide ditch or trench dug outside the walls of a city in order to make the wall a more difficult obstacle for those who would attempt to attack from the outside. A moat could be dry or filled with water, but in the conditions of the land of Israel a dry moat was more likely.

Translation:

The Hebrew word charuts with the meaning of part of a city's defenses occurs only in DAN 9:25. Interpretations have varied widely, but it is most likely that it refers to a moat as defined above. RSV and NASB have "moat"; NIV says "trench"; CEV expands to "a trench will be dug around the city for protection." GNT "strong defenses" may also serve as a model.

See also the note on ISA 22:11 at 3.10 Pool<REALIA:3.10>.

City gate

3.13.3.5 City gate

References:

Hebrew דֶּלֶת (deleth) DEU 3:5, JOS 6:26, JDG 16:3, 1SA 21:14, 1SA 23:7, 1KI 16:34, 2CH 8:5, 2CH 14:6, NEH 3:1, NEH 3:3, NEH 3:6, NEH 3:13, NEH 3:14, NEH 3:15, NEH 6:1, NEH 7:1, NEH 7:3, NEH 13:19, PSA 107:16, ISA 45:1, ISA 45:2, JER 49:31, EZK 26:2, EZK 38:11

Hebrew פֶּתַח, שַׁעַר (pethach, pethach sha'ar) GEN 38:14, JOS 8:29, JOS 20:4, JDG 9:35, JDG 9:40, JDG 9:44, JDG 18:16, JDG 18:17, JDG 19:27, 2SA 11:23, 1KI 17:10, 1KI 22:10, 2KI 7:3, 2KI 10:8, 1CH 19:9, 2CH 18:9, PRO 1:21, PRO 8:3, JER 1:15, JER 19:2

Hebrew שַׁעַר (sha'ar) GEN 19:1, GEN 22:17, GEN 23:10, GEN 23:18, GEN 24:60, GEN 34:20, GEN 34:24, GEN 34:24, EXO 20:10, DEU 12:12, DEU 12:15, DEU 12:17, DEU 12:18, DEU 12:21, DEU 14:21, DEU 14:27, DEU 14:28, DEU 14:29, DEU 15:7, DEU 15:22, DEU 16:5, DEU 16:11, DEU 16:14, DEU 16:18, DEU 17:2, DEU 17:5, DEU 17:8, DEU 18:6, DEU 22:15, DEU 22:24, DEU 23:17, DEU 24:14, DEU 25:7, DEU 26:12, DEU 28:52, DEU 28:52, DEU 28:55, DEU 28:57, DEU 31:12, JOS 2:5, JOS 2:7, JOS 7:5, JDG 5:8, JDG 5:11, JDG 9:40, JDG 16:2, JDG 16:3, JDG 18:16, JDG 18:17, RUT 4:1, RUT 4:10, RUT 4:11, 1SA 4:18, 1SA 9:18, 1SA 17:52, 1SA 21:14, 2SA 3:27, 2SA 10:8, 2SA 11:23, 2SA 15:2, 2SA 18:4, 2SA 18:24, 2SA 18:24, 2SA 19:1, 2SA 19:9, 2SA 19:9, 2SA 23:15, 2SA 23:16, 1KI 8:37, 2KI 7:1, 2KI 7:3, 2KI 7:17, 2KI 7:17, 2KI 7:18, 2KI 7:20, 2KI 9:31, 2KI 10:8, 2KI 14:13, 2KI 14:13, 2KI 23:8, 1CH 11:17, 1CH 11:18, 2CH 6:28, 2CH 25:23, 2CH 25:23, 2CH 26:9, 2CH 26:9, 2CH 32:6, 2CH 33:14, NEH 1:3, NEH 2:3, NEH 2:13, NEH 2:13, NEH 2:13, NEH 2:14, NEH 2:15, NEH 2:17, NEH 3:1, NEH 3:3, NEH 3:13, NEH 3:13, NEH 3:14, NEH 3:15, NEH 3:26, NEH 3:28, NEH 3:29, NEH 3:31, NEH 3:32, NEH 6:1, NEH 7:3, NEH 8:1, NEH 8:3, NEH 8:16, NEH 8:16, NEH 11:19, NEH 12:25, NEH 12:30, NEH 12:31, NEH 12:37, NEH 12:37, NEH 12:39, NEH 12:39, NEH 12:39, NEH 12:39, NEH 12:39, NEH 13:19, NEH 13:19, NEH 13:22, JOB 5:4, JOB 29:7, JOB 31:21, PSA 69:13, PSA 122:2, PSA 127:5, PRO 8:3, PRO 22:22, PRO 24:7, PRO 31:23, PRO 31:31, SNG 7:5, ISA 14:31, ISA 22:7, ISA 24:12, ISA 26:2, ISA 28:6, ISA 29:21, ISA 45:1, ISA 54:12, ISA 60:11, ISA 60:18, ISA 62:10, JER 17:19, JER 17:19, JER 17:20, JER 17:21, JER 17:24, JER 17:25, JER 17:27, JER 17:27, JER 22:19, JER 31:38, JER 31:40, JER 39:3, JER 39:4, JER 51:58, JER 52:7, LAM 1:4, LAM 2:9, LAM 4:12, LAM 5:14, EZK 21:20, EZK 21:27, EZK 26:10, EZK 48:31, EZK 48:31, EZK 48:31, EZK 48:31, EZK 48:31, EZK 48:32, EZK 48:32, EZK 48:32, EZK 48:32, EZK 48:33, EZK 48:33, EZK 48:33, EZK 48:33, EZK 48:34, EZK 48:34, EZK 48:34, EZK 48:34, AMO 5:10, AMO 5:12, AMO 5:15, OBA 1:11, OBA 1:11, OBA 1:13, MIC 1:9, MIC 1:12, MIC 2:13, NAM 3:13, ZEP 1:10, ZEC 8:16, ZEC 14:10, ZEC 14:10, ZEC 14:10

Greek θύρα (thura) ACT 3:2, 1MA 4:38, 1MA 12:38

Greek πύλη (pulē) MAT 7:13, MAT 7:13, MAT 7:14, MAT 16:18, LUK 7:12, ACT 3:10, ACT 9:24, ACT 12:10, ACT 16:13, HEB 13:12, TOB 11:15, TOB 11:16, JDT 1:3, JDT 1:4, JDT 1:4, JDT 7:22, JDT 8:33, JDT 10:6, JDT 10:9, JDT 13:10, JDT 13:11, JDT 13:11, JDT 13:12, JDT 13:13, SIR 49:13, 1MA 5:22, 1MA 5:47, 1MA 9:50, 1MA 12:48, 1MA 13:33, 1MA 15:39, 2MA 10:36, 3MA 5:48

Greek πυλών (pulōn) ACT 14:13, REV 21:12, REV 21:12, REV 21:13, REV 21:13, REV 21:13, REV 21:13, REV 21:15, REV 21:21, REV 21:21, REV 21:25, REV 22:14, 2MA 1:8, 2MA 3:19, 2MA 8:33, 1ES 1:15, 1ES 5:46, 1ES 7:9, 1ES 9:38, 1ES 9:41

References:

Gatekeeper:

Hebrew שׁוֹעֵר (sho'er) 2KI 7:10, 2KI 7:11, 1CH 9:18, 1CH 9:22, 1CH 9:24, 1CH 9:26, 1CH 15:18, 1CH 15:23, 1CH 15:24, 1CH 16:38, 1CH 23:5, 1CH 26:1, 1CH 26:12, 1CH 26:19, 2CH 8:14, 2CH 23:4, 2CH 23:19, 2CH 31:14, 2CH 34:13, 2CH 35:15, EZR 2:42, EZR 2:70, EZR 7:7, EZR 10:24, NEH 7:1, NEH 7:45, NEH 7:72, NEH 10:29, NEH 10:40, NEH 11:19, NEH 12:25, NEH 12:45, NEH 12:47, NEH 13:5

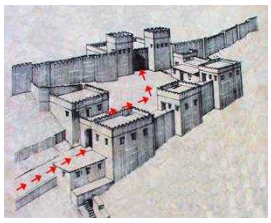
Aramaic תְּרַע (tara') DAN 3:26

Greek θυρωρός (thurōros) JHN 10:3, 1ES 1:15, 1ES 5:28, 1ES 5:45, 1ES 7:9, 1ES 8:5, 1ES 8:22, 1ES 9:25

Description and usage:

Reconstructed eastern gate towers of Arad (© Gilabrand, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The gate was an entranceway into a city through its defensive wall. Large gates could also be found at the entrances to large complexes such as the Temple or the residences of the rich. Gateway construction varied at different periods, having two, four, or six parallel guardrooms on either side of the gateway. At other times gateways were built having one or more ninety degree turns, usually to the left (in order to expose the side of the attacking soldier which was not covered by his shield). The entrance of the gateway was closed by a thick door, normally made of wood. The door was usually made of two parts, each part hanging on hinges from each side of the gateway. These two parts of the gate were pushed together and then secured in place by one or more heavy wooden bars from the inside (see 3.13.3.5.1 Gate bar, bolt<REALIA:3.13.3.5.1>).

Translation:



Drawing demonstrating the entrance through an ancient city gate complex (© United Bible Societies, 2001)In most of the passages listed above (for example, ACT 14:13), the reference is to the entranceway and not specifically to the gates as objects. In some passages, however (for example, JDG 16:3), it is the doors of the entranceway that are in focus. In many cultures walled towns with gates are unknown, and in JDG 16:3 it may be necessary to expand the literal clause “he took hold of the doors of the gate of the city” as follows: “he took hold of the large doors in the wall that surrounded the city.”

In ancient cities, business and discussion were often conducted in the gateway (see GEN 23:10; GEN 23:18; RUT 4:1; RUT 4:11; see also 3.13.2 Square, marketplace<REALIA:3.13.2>). It was the place where the elders or important men of the city gathered (JOB 29:7). The city gate could also serve as a place of judgment (DEU 21:19; JOS 20:4) or punishment (DEU 17:5; DEU 22:24). JOB 31:21 probably refers to the city gate as a place of judgment also. The second line of this verse is literally “because I saw my help in the gate.” This refers to having the support and backing of the other officials in the town. If Job had wanted to mistreat anyone, he could have counted on those men who sat on the town council to defend him. GNT “knowing I could win in court” means that Job has the support of the local court system (that met at the city gate) to defend his case. We may also render the whole verse as “I have never threatened to harm an orphan, even though I knew the officials would be on my side if I did.” PSA 127:5 also refers to the city gate as a court. The second half of this verse is literally “He shall not be put to shame when he speaks with his enemies in the gate” (RSV). The “enemies in the gate” are a man’s adversaries in a legal dispute; the open space near the inner gate of the city was the place where legal disputes were settled. If he had a number of grown sons with him, a man would be more likely to win in a legal dispute with his adversaries. In some languages there is a term for a designated place in the village where village elders meet for hearings. In cases where there is no such customary place, “in the gate” is sometimes rendered “in the place where men meet to decide matters.” Compare also PRO 22:22; PRO 24:7; PRO 31:23; ISA 29:21; LAM 5:14; AMO 5:10; AMO 5:12; AMO 5:15; ZEC 8:16.

GEN 22:17; GEN 24:60: The literal expression “shall possess the gates of their enemies” (RSV) in GEN 22:17 is an idiomatic way of saying “will conquer their enemies” (GNT) or “will defeat their enemies” (CEV).

EXO 20:10: Here a Hebrew idiom speaks of people who are “within your gates” (RSV). This refers to the territory controlled by someone. So GNT has “in your country,” CEV uses “in your towns,” and NCV says “in your cities.” Compare DEU 5:14; DEU 12:12; DEU 12:15; DEU 12:18; DEU 12:18; DEU 12:21; DEU 14:21; DEU 14:27; DEU 14:28; DEU 14:29; DEU 15:7. Generally this idiom may be rendered “in your land,” “in your towns,” or “in your cities.” The expression should not be misunderstood as referring to people who, by a different metaphor, “sit in the gate,” that is, are members of the local leadership.

RUT 3:11: In the literal expression “the whole gate of my people,” “gate” refers to the city, and “the whole gate” is a reference to the whole city in the sense of “all the people of the city” or “all of the citizens.” It is rare that a translator can use a term for “gate” in reference to a city. RUT 4:10 speaks literally of Mahlon’s name not being “cut off ... from the gate of his place.” Here again “gate” is a metonym for the whole town. GNT expresses this positively, saying “his family line will continue ... in his hometown.” CEV is also good: “he will be remembered in this town.”

2SA 18:24: The literal phrase “between the two gates” (RSV) reflects the construction of city gates. The stronger walled cities had an outer and an inner gate, with a covered passage or narrow entrance hall between them. Along the sides of the passage were usually rooms occupied by guards (see 3.13.3.5.2 Guardroom<REALIA:3.13.3.5.2>). The translator can make the picture reasonably clear with an expanded translation, for example, “between the inner and outer gates” (NIV) or “between the inner and outer gates of the city” (GNT). CEV is similar to NIV and

adds the following note: “The city gate was often like a tower in the city wall, with one gate on the outside of the wall and another gate on the inside of the wall.”

PRO 31:31: “and let her works praise her in the gates” (RSV). Here “gates” stands for the place where people gather, a public place. CEV says “praise her in public for what she has done” (similarly NCV), and GNT has “She deserves the respect of everyone.”

MAT 16:18: The literal phrase “the gates of Hades” is an idiom for death or the power that death holds over humanity. RSV and NEB have “the powers of death.” For the last clause of this verse, CEV says “death itself will not have any power over it.” There is a parallel expression in ISA 38:10, where Hezekiah complains that the little time he has to live will be dominated by the fact of his impending death: “I had thought: I must depart in the middle of my days; I have been consigned to the gates of Sheol [meaning ‘world of the dead’] For the rest of my years” (NJPSV). Compare GNT: “I thought that in the prime of life I was going to the world of the dead, Never to live out my life.” In both passages the translator should not try to retain the reference to gates unless it will be natural in the receptor language; for example, in ISA 38:10 in English, Hezekiah might speak of being “at death’s door.”

ACT 3:2: There are two opinions concerning the identification of the gate mentioned only in this passage. Some authorities believe it was the Nicanor Gate, made of polished Corinthian bronze, which according to Josephus exceeded all the other gates in value and which gave access from the Women’s Court to the Court of Israel. But from the context, which says that Peter and John were “going in,” it seems more probable the gate here called “Beautiful” was the Golden Gate, also called Shushan. Jewish tradition knows nothing about a gate called the Beautiful Gate. However, translators do not need to concern themselves with the identification of the gate; it is sufficient to say “the Beautiful Gate” or “the gate called Beautiful.” Translators normally capitalize the name of the gate.

About 40 verses make reference to “gatekeeper[s].” A gatekeeper was a man who was responsible to sit by a closed gate and identify those desiring to enter. He would open the gate (of the city, the Temple, a palace, or perhaps to the courtyard of a rich man) only for those who were allowed to enter.

Gate bar, bolt

3.13.3.5.1 Gate bar, bolt

References:

Hebrew בַּד (bad) HOS 11:6

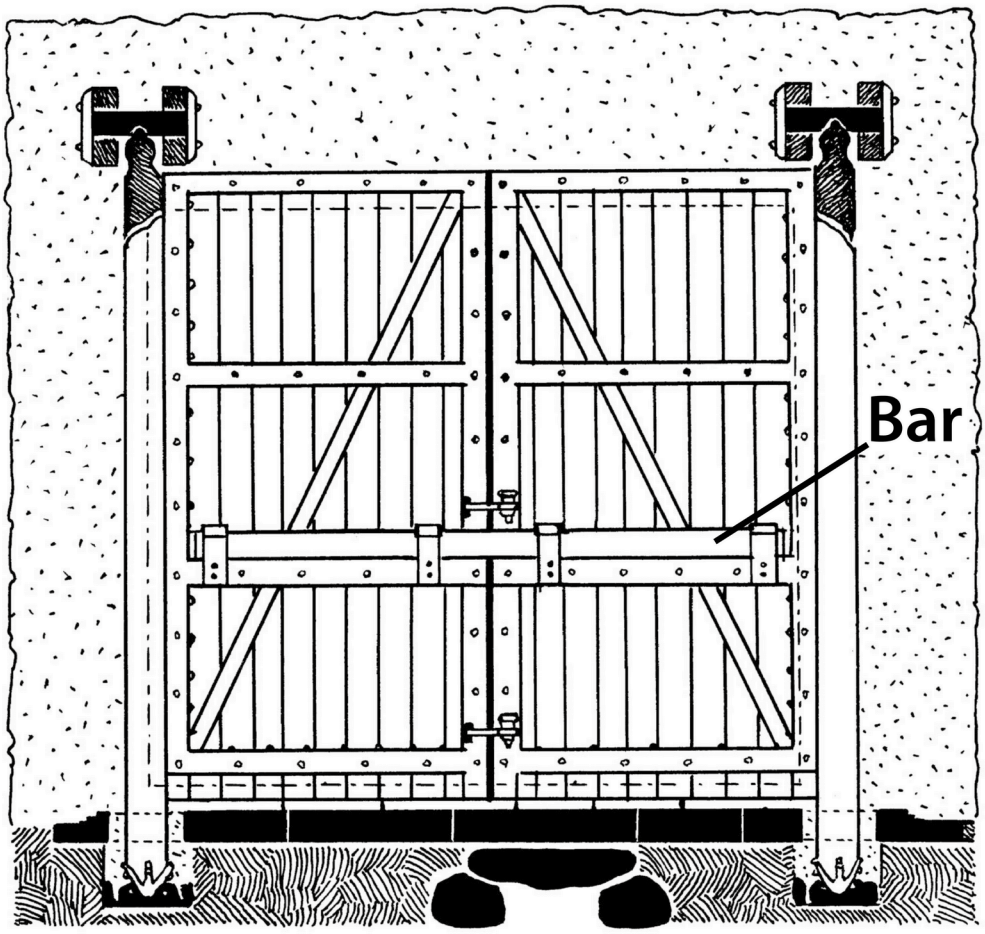
Hebrew בְּרִיחַ (briach) DEU 3:5, JDG 16:3, 1SA 23:7, 1KI 4:13, 2CH 8:5, 2CH 14:6, NEH 3:3, NEH 3:6, NEH 3:13, NEH 3:14, NEH 3:15, JOB 38:10, PSA 107:16, PSA 147:13, PRO 18:19, ISA 45:2, JER 49:31, JER 51:30, LAM 2:9, EZK 38:11, AMO 1:5, JON 2:7, NAM 3:13

Hebrew מִנְעָל (min‘al) DEU 33:25

Hebrew מַנְעוּל (man‘ul) NEH 3:3, NEH 3:6, NEH 3:13, NEH 3:14, NEH 3:15

Greek μοχλός (mochlos) SIR 28:25, SIR 49:13, LJE 1:17, 1MA 9:50, 1MA 12:38, 1MA 13:33

Description:



Drawing of a gate locked with a bar (© Deutsche Bibelgesellschaft, Stuttgart by United Bible Societies)The bars of gates were usually made of wood (see the description of the gate at 3.13.3.5 City gate<REALIA:3.13.3.5>). However, there are several specific references to bars made of metal (1KI 4:13; PSA 107:16; ISA 45:2), but even these bars may have been made of wood that was reinforced with metal.

Translation:

In some languages it may be necessary to use a descriptive phrase for “bar,” such as “big stick that held the doors closed.” Another model is “bar that bolts the doors of the mouth/opening/entrance in the walls/fences around the city.” Since the bar functioned to secure the gate in much the same way a modern lock would, translators may wish to speak of a “lock” rather than a bar; for example, in JER 49:31GNT refers to “locks.” In DEU 3:5GNT presents another model: “bars to lock the gates.”

JOB 38:10: See the discussion under 3.1.3 Gate or gateway to house or building complex<REALIA:3.1.3>.

In AMO 1:5RSV renders the Hebrew word briach literally in the first line, saying “I will break the bar of Damascus.” Like RSV, most translations treat the first line as a literal threat to destroy the city of Damascus. NIV has “I will break down the gate of Damascus,” CEV says “I will break through the gates of Damascus,” and GNT translates “I will smash the city gates of Damascus.” This is also the only option presented by A Handbook on The Book of Amos. It is possible, however, to see a parallelism between the first two lines of the verse and the last two lines, where “gate bar” in the first line is parallel to “scepter” (shevet in Hebrew) in the third line. This would mean that the gate bar is a metaphor for the ruler. Of the translations consulted, only REB comes close to this approach with “I shall crush the nobles of Damascus ... and the sceptred ruler of Beth-eden.”

NAM 3:13: It is not clear whether the bars and gates mentioned here are to be taken literally or figuratively. If they are understood figuratively, then the “bars” probably stand for the fortresses that guarded the mountain passes, which are called “gates” earlier in the verse. If they are understood literally, then the “bars” would be the wooden beams that prevented the gates of Nineveh from being opened. GNT follows this interpretation and renders the last half of this verse as “Fire will destroy the bars across your gates.” Probably it is better either to take both the gates and bars as figurative, or both as literal. If translators take both the gates and bars as figurative, a possible translation model is “The borders of your land are wide open to your enemies, and fire will destroy your fortresses.”

NEH 3:3; NEH 3:6; NEH 3:13; NEH 3:14; NEH 3:15 lists both briach and man‘ul as part of the gate. They were in fact parts of the system for securing the gate from the inside so that it could not be opened. The Hebrew word briach refers to a pole or bar, while the word man‘ul comes from a root meaning “to close.” Most translations render the two objects as “bolts and bars.” CEV “metal bolts and wooden beams as locks” suggests the materials from which these objects were made and the function they served. The exact structure and function of the man‘ul is not clear. The rendering of GECL (expanded a bit) may come close: “the bars and the mechanisms that secured them in place.”

Guardroom

3.13.3.5.2 Guardroom

References:

Hebrew תָּא (t’a) 1KI 14:28, 2CH 12:11, EZK 40:7, EZK 40:7, EZK 40:10, EZK 40:12, EZK 40:12, EZK 40:13, EZK 40:16, EZK 40:21, EZK 40:21, EZK 40:29, EZK 40:29, EZK 40:33, EZK 40:33, EZK 40:36, EZK 40:36

Description:

Ancient city gates were sometimes constructed with guardrooms on either side of the entrance. These usually came in sets of two, four, or six rooms (see 3.13.3.5 City gate<REALIA:3.13.3.5>).

Translation:

The Hebrew word t’a means simply “chamber,” “room,” “cell,” or “compartment.” The purpose of the room in 1KI 14:28 and 2CH 12:11 is different from that in EZK 40:0. Many languages will need to use two different words or expressions.

1KI 14:28; 2CH 12:11: In these verses t’a refers to a room where valuable objects were kept under guard, although it is possible that the room in question was not actually designed as a treasury. In this context most translations render it “guardroom” (RSV, GNT). NJPSV has “armory of the guards.” GECL avoids a technical term and has “their [bronze shields] place.” This might be expanded to “the place where they were kept” or “the place where they were guarded.”

EZK 40:0: In this chapter the prophet Ezekiel describes the gates of an ideal Temple he saw in a vision. Each gate was constructed as a kind of corridor or covered passageway. On each side of this corridor were three small three-sided rooms (t’a in Hebrew) facing each other. In these rooms sat soldiers who guarded the access to the outer and inner courts of the Temple. Here again, most translations have “guardrooms” (GNT, CEV). Luther (followed by GECL) provides an alternative, translating t’a as “niche.” This may actually be more accurate than “room,” since the area had walls on three sides with the side facing the passageway remaining open, making it more of a “recess” or “alcove.”

Armory, arsenal

3.13.4 Armory, arsenal

References:

Hebrew אוֹצָר (’otsar) JER 50:25

Hebrew בֵּית, כְּלִי (beyth kli) 2KI 20:13, ISA 39:2

Hebrew נֶשֶׁק (nesheq) NEH 3:19

Description:

Reconstructed amphitheater at Caesarea Maritima (© Doron Horovitz, Israel Government Press Office)No specific description can be given for the armory. It is to be assumed that it was possible to close the place so that there was limited access.

Translation:

Many languages may lack a specific word for a room or a building where many weapons are stored. It should normally be possible to use an expanded phrase, for example, “where he kept his weapons,” (CEV; 2KI 20:13) or “the place where my weapons are stored” (GNT; JER 50:25). The NCV rendering of JER 50:25 shows that a general word for a storage place will work well: “The LORD has opened up his storeroom and brought out the weapons ….”

Theater

3.13.5 Theater

References:

Greek θέατρον (theatron) ACT 19:29, ACT 19:31

Description and usage:

The theater was normally a semicircular open structure capable of seating several thousand people and used for public assemblies.

Translation:

In some languages the most appropriate equivalent for “theater” is actually “meeting place.” In other languages translators may use a term that designates an “enclosure.” Translators should avoid a word that has the narrow meaning of “cinema.” The ancient theater was used for a variety of public events, including drama presentations. Perhaps for this reason, CEV has rendered the Greek word theatron in ACT 19:29 as “place where the town meetings were held” and has left the word untranslated in ACT 19:31.

Stadium

3.13.6 Stadium

References:

Greek ἱππόδρομος (hippodromos) 3MA 4:11, 3MA 5:46, 3MA 6:16

Greek παλαίστρα (palaistra) 2MA 4:14

Greek στάδιον (stadion) 1CO 9:24

Description and usage:

Model of a Roman stadium (© Ray Pritz by United Bible Societies)The stadium was an open, oval area (frequently including a racetrack) around which was built an enclosed series of tiers of seats for those who came to watch the spectacles.

Translation:

In 1CO 9:24 the important feature is not the stadium as a construction, but as a place where races were conducted. Accordingly, the literal phrase “all the runners in the stadium” may very well be rendered as “all the runners who are racing.” The focus here is upon the competition rather than upon the type of place in which the competition took place.

Discus

3.13.6.1 Discus

Reference:

Greek δίσκος (diskos) 2MA 4:14

Description and usage:

The discus was a round, flat disk about the size of a small dinner plate. Throwing such a disk to the greatest possible distance was part of the athletic contests of the ancient Greeks.

Translation:

Athletic contests in ancient Greece were inseparably connected with the religious cult. This is an important aspect of the discus throwing in 2MA 4:14, and this aspect should be preserved in translation, even if it means not mentioning the specific sport of throwing the discus; for example, GNT renders the last part of this verse as "they would rush off to take part in the games that were forbidden by our Law."

Gymnasium, school

3.13.7 Gymnasium, school

References:

Greek γυμνασία, γυμνάσιον (gumnasia, gumnasion) 1MA 1:14, 2MA 4:9, 2MA 4:12, 4MA 11:20

Greek σχολή (scholē) ACT 19:9

Description and usage:

The gymnasium was an open area where Greek men did both physical and intellectual training together.

Translation:

Transliterating the Greek word gumnasion as "gymnasium" is misleading in English and may be also in other languages. In several modern European languages the word for "gymnasium" means "school," which reflects the aspect of intellectual training but misses the physical training that also took place there.

2MA 4:9 mentions two institutions together, which are called gumnasion and efebeion in Greek. The second word indicates a special place for youth gatherings. RSV somewhat misses the point by saying "a gymnasium and a body of youth for it." GNT combines the two words with "a stadium where young men could train." Other possible models are "a gymnasium and youth centre" (NJB) and "a gymnasium and a youth club for it" (NAB). NAB adds this note: "Youth club: an educational institution in which young men were trained both in Greek intellectual culture and in physical fitness."

Archives, library

3.13.8 Archives, library

References:

Aramaic בֵּיתגְּנַז (beyth gnaz) EZR 5:17, EZR 6:1

Greek βιβλιοθήκη (bibliothēkē) 2MA 2:13

Greek βιβλιοφυλάκιον (bibliofulakion) 1ES 6:20, 1ES 6:22

Description and usage:

(Image generated by ChatGPT using OpenAI technology)The library was a place for the storage of official or public documents. There was no distinctive structure for such a building.

Translation:

In 2MA 4:9 several translations render the Greek word biblion as “archives” (RSV, GNT). However, here this word refers more to “books” or “records” rather than to the place were those records were kept.

Tell, mound

3.13.9 Tell, mound

References:

Hebrew גַּל, נצה (gal (nitsim)) 2KI 19:25, JOB 15:28, ISA 25:2, ISA 37:26, JER 9:10, JER 51:37

Hebrew מַפָּלָה, מְעִי (m'i mapalah) ISA 17:1

Hebrew עִי ('i) PSA 79:1, JER 26:18, MIC 1:6, MIC 3:12

Hebrew תֵּל (tel) DEU 13:17, JOS 8:28, JOS 11:13, JER 30:18, JER 49:2

Description:

Tell (Bet She'an) (© Grauesel, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The tell was a hill formed by the accumulation of ruins of a succession of ancient towns. There are numerous tells in the Bible lands, and many have been excavated and identified as ancient biblical cities.

Translation:

Ancient cities and towns were often destroyed in war or abandoned after plague or famine, and the buildings collapsed over time. Frequently new cities were built on the ruins of the old cities without clearing away all of the foundations and buildup of the former cities. This process of building on top of the old gradually created an artificial hill or mound. In biblical descriptions these mounds represent destruction and decay. However, cities built on top of these mounds had a higher elevation and were thus easier to fortify and defend.

With JOS 11:13 and JER 30:18 as possible exceptions, the words listed above all connote something negative, not just a mound on which a city sits but a pile of ruins resulting from destructive activity.

JER 49:2: The literal clause “it will become a desolate tell” is rendered by NCV as “It will become a hill covered with ruins.” Some versions do not try to preserve the element of elevation; for example, GNT and CEV have “it will be left in ruins.” GECL provides a useful model with “Rabbah will become a heap of rubble.”

Platform

3.13.10 Platform

References:

Hebrew כִּיּוֹר (kiyor) 2CH 6:13

Hebrew מִגְדָּל (migdal) NEH 8:4

Greek βῆμα (bēma) 2MA 13:26, 1ES 9:42

Description and usage:

Ruins of a platform (© Ray Pritz by United Bible Societies)The platform was a large raised surface on which someone stood to address a crowd of people. The one described in 2CH 6:13 was made of bronze, and was 2.5 meters (8 feet) square and 1.5 meters (5 feet) high. These dimensions may serve as an approximate model for all of the references above, although the others may have been made of stone (as in the illustration) or wood.

Translation:

Many cultures are familiar with a special place or structure from which a person addresses an assembled crowd.

The Hebrew word migdal in NEH 8:4 literally means “tower.” RSV “pulpit” sounds anachronistic, even though the structure upon which Ezra stood fulfilled a purpose similar to that of a modern pulpit in some Christian traditions. NJB “dais” is accurate but obscure for most English speakers. “Platform” (GNT) or “high platform” (CEV, NCV) is good. The same rendering should be used at 1ES 9:42.